

NEAR SHOEMAKER

Space probe

The Near Earth Asteroid Rendezvous (NEAR) spacecraft was renamed NEAR Shoemaker after Gene Shoemaker, a scientist who investigated craters on Earth that had been blasted out by asteroids. Designed to study asteroid Eros, it became the first space mission to orbit an asteroid and to land on its surface. It found Eros to be a peanut-shaped world, scarred with over 100,000 craters.

DATA FILE



SIZE: 2.7 m (9 ft) long



DATE OF LAUNCH: 17 February 1996



MISSION DURATION: 5 years, 12 days (last contact)



SPACE AGENCY: NASA



Eros as seen by
NEAR Shoemaker

Solar panels
provide power

Sensor to measure
Eros's magnetism

Asteroid Eros
could hit Earth
within the
next few
million years.